UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

ENGL 1405-01 - AY2027-T1

Unit 2 Assignment

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Enlightenment and Jonathan Swift's "A Modest Proposal"

The Enlightenment, also known as the Age of Reason, was an important literary and cultural movement that emphasized reason, logic, observation, individual thought, and the questioning of traditional authority. The movement developed strongly in Europe during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. Enlightenment thinkers challenged superstition and encouraged people to use reason to understand society and improve human life. Literature of this period often addressed political, religious, economic, and social issues. Writers also used satire, essays, poetry, and other forms to question institutions and expose problems in society. The movement reflected the belief that rational thinking could help people identify injustice and challenge ideas that were accepted without sufficient examination (English Units, 2017).

One important author associated with this period is Jonathan Swift, and his work "A Modest Proposal" provides a powerful example of Enlightenment literature. The work was published in 1729 and responds to poverty and social conditions in Ireland. Swift presents an apparently rational economic solution to poverty: poor families should sell their infants as food for wealthy people. Although the proposal is horrifying, Swift does not actually support it. Instead, he uses satire and irony to criticize the political and economic attitudes that allowed poor people to be treated as objects rather than human beings (Swift, 1729).

Several common literary elements demonstrate how the work reflects the intellectual concerns of the Enlightenment. First, Swift uses the language and structure of a serious economic argument. The speaker discusses numbers, costs, benefits, and practical solutions as though he were presenting a reasonable policy. This logical presentation makes the proposal initially appear rational. However, the extreme nature of the proposal exposes the weakness of treating a human problem only as an economic calculation. Second, Swift uses irony, because the speaker's apparent seriousness contrasts sharply with the cruel reality of his proposal. Readers are expected to recognize that the literal argument is absurd and that Swift's real purpose is social criticism.

The work also demonstrates the Enlightenment tendency to question authority and established social practices. Instead of accepting the existing treatment of poor people, Swift forces readers to reconsider the responsibility of political and economic institutions. His satire encourages readers to think critically rather than simply accept conventional explanations for poverty. The exaggerated proposal therefore becomes a tool for rational criticism.

Overall, “A Modest Proposal” demonstrates how Enlightenment literature could use reason, irony, and critical thinking to address serious social problems. Swift's work does not provide a literal solution to poverty; instead, it challenges readers to recognize the injustice and lack of humanity within existing attitudes. This combination of intellectual criticism and literary satire makes the work an effective example of the Enlightenment movement.

References

English Units. (2017, June 10). *Literary genres and subgenres (fiction, nonfiction, drama, and poetry)* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oarGRayak5o

Swift, J. (1729). *A modest proposal*. Corpus of Electronic Texts, University College Cork. https://celt.ucc.ie/document/E700001-022/